



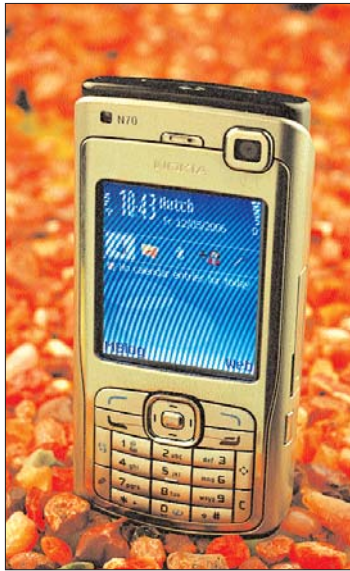
FIFTH ANNIVERSARY

Digital Passion | Cell Phone Test

Samsung X700 had a Micro SD slot, which is about half the size of Mini SD. Note that these memory standards are incompatible with each other for the most part—except MMC and RSMMC, for which an adapter can be used. For exchanging data between non-alike cards, a card reader will have to be used.

Coming to support for document viewing, once again all the Symbian based Nokia phones had the option to view MS office documents. This is a definite plus, but not necessarily a judge for the other phones, as the Nokia's are classed as Smartphones, with emphasis on the smart features, like enhancing productivity, PDF viewing etc, while the others are more focused on multimedia. This doesn't mean that they give up on functionality in any way, just that the jack of all trades principle is being put to use by manufacturers here, it just depends what combination of features they are focusing on.

Coming to miscellaneous features and quirks, there was a very notable feature that some of the Nokia phones had, which were absent throughout the board. The keypad on the Nokia 6630, 6681, N70 and N91, (not in this comparison), models intelligently lit up when the



The Nokia N70 - Feature-rich beauty

keypad was in use in a darkish area. This is achieved by a light sensor placed atop the phone that will cause the keypad to illuminate once you operate it in dimly lit areas. Very nifty indeed, and a small, and not very costly feature to add! We would like to see more cell phone manufacturers incorporating such features that actually work!

Rs 15,000 and Above

Looks-wise the Samsung D600 is ahead of the other two cellphones in this category, mainly because of its small footprint. The fit and finish of the slider mechanism is also top notch, as is the feel of the keypad, and its layout. Generally slider phones tend to get a bit cramped as far as the keypad layout goes, no such problems here. Second prize goes to the N70, with a steel chrome front and compact looks. One sore point is the slight gap between the chrome bezel and the rest of the body, this becomes a bit of an eyesore after awhile, if you happen to be choosy about fit and finish. Build quality is however right up with the best. The 6681 is the ugly duckling of the lot, by no means an ugly phone on its own, but the chrome call and cancel buttons were just a little too gaudy.

Coming to the cameras of these phones, the quality of the 6681 was found to be lacking on paper—with specs, as well as in practice. The 1.3 megapixel camera just couldn't keep up with the cameras on the N70 and the D600, both rated at 2 megapixels. Picture quality of the N70 was slightly better than the Samsung D600, particularly when using zoom. Video shooting on the N70 was also better.

Note that by zooming we mean a small amount of zoom—any serious zooming distorts the quality of the shot/video, as all the cellphones tested have digital zooms, which unlike an optical zoom, reduces clarity when used. The Samsung was a tad slow in clicking images however, ditto the Nokia 6681, though this was more noticeable on the former. The N70 had no such problems.

The N70 has one camera in the front and one in the rear. This is for video conferencing, and the only issue here is the front camera is VGA, and not a good one at that! It's the rear camera that sports the 2.0 megapixel capture resolution. Both the 6681 and the N70 have sliders that cover the rear cameras, and sliding them down activates the camera mode.

One irritating point noted here—both the Nokia sliders, although smooth to operate, actually rub against the back bezel, and after 50 to 60 times of sliding the 6681 back and forth, the chrome trim surrounding the camera lens actually started wearing off due to this movement. The N70 fared slightly better, but there were scuff marks beginning to appear as well. Quite an eyesore for someone investing as much as these cell phones demand!

Screen clarity is well and truly ruled by the odd man out in the trio—the D600. This screen, (like the X700), was crisp and ultra sharp, Samsung really does produce top quality displays! The icons look lifelike, and the menu layout is just so clean.

Nokia 7710

Lifestyle Phones

All display and no keypad makes the 7710 a confused phone. Nokia's attempt at a complete touch screen phone with no number keypad has most people pleasantly surprised, while some seem to have their own reservations—the primary reason being the said absence and its slow processor. Why are the first of a new Nokia line always slow? First the 6600, and now the 7710.

On the bright side is the wonderful and massive 640 X 320 wide screen display which is great for viewing videos. The Series 90 platform used by the 7710 has several applications written for it, and playing an MPG or an AVI file is possible. Entertainment to go! Its stereo loudspeaker is well... really loud! A 'mere' 1 megapixel camera disappoints a little, considering its price and other abilities. Video is recorded in the standard 176 x 144 resolution.

This is a multimedia phone in the true sense, if you ignore the lag in opening of videos, that is. With GPRS, HSCSD and EDGE support, internet experience is only enhanced by the large screen. With an extensive calendar and innumerable Series 90 applications that can be further installed, the 7710 can do double duty on your office work as well.

The stylus slots in neatly and is as easy to retrieve. The touchpad is sensitive enough and takes in user input without fuss. Simple navigation and selection can be done using the limited keypad too. Nokia wins again in the department of navigation—a new user can get to the different features in no time at all.

The Series 90's flexibility is evident in the 7710. The number of entries in the phonebook, message box, received and dialled call-log, all depend on the shared memory, which pleasantly is 90MB. If you use the MMC card to store pictures and videos, you get virtually unlimited phonebook and log entries.

The 7710 is not *chic* per se, but if size matters, it can be an attention grabber. If all fails, just pump up the volume or turn on the video and you will have a crowd around you. We tested this feature and it works!

- + Large and clear display, sensitive touchpad
- No keypad

Rating: 3/5

